

Indian single malts,” says Hemanth Rao, Founder of the Single Malt Amateur Club that has around 4,500 active members.

It started over a decade ago when Bengaluru-based Amrut Distilleries’ Indian single malt, Amrut Fusion, was rated the third finest whisky in the world in 2010 by the *Whisky Bible*, putting Indian single malts on the globe. While Amrut has been in the liquor business since 1948, it was only in 2004 that it decided to launch Indian single malts. Says Rakshit Jagdale, Managing Director of Amrut Distilleries, “I was doing my MBA in the UK and as part of my thesis my father wanted me to check if there was potential to market an Indian single malt whisky in UK. We did a lot of sampling and the response for Amrut was great.” Subsequently, it was launched in Scotland in 2004.

92 | “My father was very clear that we must sell this product abroad first. Get all the accolades and then introduce it in India. So it was only in 2011 that we launched in India,” says Jagdale. Since then things have only been on a high. Today India accounts for 60 per cent of Amrut’s sales, and Fusion—so called because it is made of 80 per cent Indian malted barley and 20 per cent Scottish peated barley—continues to be a bestseller. Whisky collectors look forward to Amrut’s limited edition luxury releases. The Greedy Angels 12-year-old, released in 2016, is priced at \$1,000. Only 15 cases (each with 12 bottles) were released globally and while US stocks are completely sold out, you may be able to pick up a bottle in Europe. In July, Amrut will launch the Greedy Angels 8-year-old, priced at ₹16,000. Only 48 individually numbered bottles will be available in India. Another limited edition is the Fusion XI, being launched in July-August to celebrate Fusion’s 11th anniversary. Priced at ₹25,000, only 200 cases will be launched globally, half in India.

“Indian single malts are becoming



more popular every day, posing competition to Scotch. According to industry associations, single malt brands have grown almost seven-fold in six years, accounting for over a third of the market compared to only 15 per cent in 2017,” says Vikram Damodaran, Chief Innovation Officer of Diageo India. Diageo launched an artisanal Indian single malt called Godawan in March. Distilled at Alwar, it is currently available only in Delhi and Rajasthan. Godawan, which made an appearance at the 75th Cannes Film Festival, will be launched globally by the end of May.

Another home-grown player, Radico Khaitan, has its own single malt whisky called Rampur. Distilled at its distillery in Rampur, near Moradabad, the Rampur Select was introduced to the world in 2016 at Las Vegas. Since then, Radico has launched different variants including the Rampur Double Cask,

where the malted whisky spends two-thirds of its life in American bourbon casks and the rest in sherry oloroso casks. And its latest, Rampur Asava, launched during the pandemic, is the first single malt matured in American bourbon barrels and finished in Indian Cabernet Sauvignon casks. “The temperature at Rampur varies from 42-43 degree Celsius in summer to 2 degrees in winter, so the malt interacts at a very aggressive pace with the cask,” says Sanjeev Banga, President of International Business at Radico Khaitan.

Rampur is exported to 38 countries. In the Indian market, only the Double Cask variant is available in NCR, UP, Rajasthan, Uttarakhand, and CSD canteens. The Asava is also for the global market but can be bought from the Delhi or Mumbai Duty Free. It’s priced at approximately \$115. “We have tripled our malt distillation capacity. So, we will